

Chapter 6: Resolve

Kraekon, 4 Years Ago

“So how is work going?” His mother’s voice had been friendly, but there was something in Nerys’s tone that seemed like she was leading the conversation somewhere.

“Work is going well.” When he referred to work, Kraekon was talking about his job as a guard for Duskwatch. He’d taken to his apprenticeship swimmingly four years ago—so well, in fact, that he’d been brought on as an actual guard within a couple years, despite starting his training so much later than other apprentices with the Duskwatch. “The other guards are friendly, and they even sometimes come to ask me for advice about their jobs these days. I think I’m starting to get a bit of a reputation.” Kraekon laughed—a full-belly, hearty laugh, just like his father had done. He didn’t much feel like laughing—not *that* deeply, anyway. But it always seemed to cheer up those around him, and that was the important part—so laugh he did.

“That’s good to hear. And you haven’t... heard anything weird? Nothing strange, like someone or something threatening to hurt us or to rip out our entrails or anything?” She seemed serious, but Kraekon couldn’t help but laugh at how silly it sounded.

“No, Mom, no one at work is threatening to gut me like a fish or anything.” He punctuated it with another hearty laugh. “Besides, even if they tried, there’s no way they could do it. I could beat anyone there in a fair fight, and half of them in an unfair one.” He smiled, trying to reassure her. Kraekon wasn’t sure what was on his mother’s mind, but she seemed genuinely worried.

He glanced up at the trident mounted above their fireplace. Years ago, Eric had apparently gifted it to Nerys—an odd gift for most people, but apparently, she’d loved it. The two of them had spent much of their free time together, sparring and training together, despite her frail constitution and slim frame. Ever since her husband had passed, she had been either too exhausted or too depressed to practice with it, but she’d evidently been able to even beat Eric a few times back in the day. “And if they *did* somehow hurt me, I’m sure they’d be terrified when you came after them.” His mother didn’t seem particularly amused at that.

“And what about the shades? Anything unusual? Extra activity? Has the border moved at all?” Nerys’s questions rang out rapid-fire, like she couldn’t stop herself.

“No, Mom, nothing unusual. Everything is *fine*. Are you okay? What’s this about?”

“It’s... nothing, sweetie. I’m just worried. That job took a toll on your father, and I just... don’t want anything to happen to you.” She seemed genuinely worried. Kraekon gave her the widest, most reassuring smile he could give her, then wrapped her small frame in a hug.

“I’m fine, Mom. And I’m strong. You and Dad raised me well; I can handle anything that comes my way, and if I can’t, I know I can come to you for help. Together, we can figure anything out.” Nerys smiled at him—a warm, reassuring, haunting smile.

“I know.”

That had been their anniversary; Kraekon doubted that most people would remember the day their parents got married, but after his dad had passed into the deep azure, he and his mom had made it a holiday of sorts—taking off work to spend time together as a family, reminisce about the old days, and bond together. It was a nice tradition, though he supposed that was over.

After all, he was all alone now.

Nerys had gone to visit Eric—or at least, that’s what he wanted to believe. His mom had always described the deep azure as a solitary thing, but Kraekon reckoned that, if everyone passes on to the same place, then maybe they could find their way to each other again there. Maybe, once this life was over, they could be a family once more. It may not have been a reasonable belief, but it gave him comfort—one final gift from his dear mother, he supposed.

She’d passed only a few months before; Kraekon had thought that—having already lost his dad—that he wouldn’t feel as bad about losing his mom. He couldn’t have been more wrong. Maybe it was because he knew now what it was like to be without a parent—or maybe it was because he’d had to contend with the reality he was losing her too for several weeks.

The Shadowrot is a hell of a way to die, after all.

No one could explain it. Nerys, of all people, *knew* what the Shadowrot was like. She’d seen it firsthand. And yet, the neighbors said they’d seen her eat a contaminated loaf of bread—one they’d watched her set out in the rain.

Like she’d chosen death—like she’d chosen *this* death.

The death of rotting from the inside out, of having every inch of your body twisted and corrupted and torn apart over and over again. A gruesome, horrific death.

Kraekon had stayed with her for as long as she'd held on. Despite her frail constitution, she'd held on longer than the doctors had expected, but her body's struggle was ultimately in vain. One of the last things she'd done was to look weakly up at Kraekon, lift a hand to his face, and smile at him—like everything would be alright, somehow. Like she believed in him, and she was sorry she was leaving. Her eyes said what her mouth couldn't. She had fallen into the deep azure shortly after then.

That day, Kraekon made a vow. He would push on—not just for his family, but for himself. For his friends. For this city. He didn't know why his parents did what they did—but it didn't matter. He could see it—in her eyes, in the ever-black sky, in the voices of those around him. This darkness was a sickness—a plague, eating away at the minds of those trapped inside.

For now, there wasn't much he could do; he couldn't push the darkness back through force. He'd have to combat the gloom from within, pushing himself to smile brighter, to laugh more, to bring as much joy and reassurance as he could to everyone else. And in the meantime, he would grow strong. Stronger than anyone else. Strong enough that his presence could put others at ease, knowing they would be safe. And then...

Over the past few months, since his mom's passing, Kraekon had frequently visited with Flavio and Ember, who offered to help him however he needed—though Ember often wasn't at home these days. They were off, learning magic and seeking solutions to the darkness. Kraekon didn't understand much of what Ember was learning, but to him, it seemed like they had some promising ideas—ideas that could eventually give the city a way to push back against the darkness.

Ember had tried to make it clear to Kraekon that everything they were working on was just in theory; they wouldn't be able to even *try* to get anything working for a few more years, and they might never find a breakthrough to turn theory into reality—but Kraekon had faith in his friend. They were the most intelligent and creative person he knew; if anyone could start finding a solution, it would be Ember. And when that day came, they'd need someone to rely on—someone who could carry a beacon out into the dark and fight where they could not.

Kraekon would be that someone.

In the meantime, Duskwatch needed him. The city needed protection, just in case something happened. Plus, it gave him a place to train, to push himself. He'd set his sights on rising even higher through the ranks—all the way to the top. It was something he'd already started doing unintentionally, but it had given him a sense of pride when he'd been able to tell his mom about it.

And so, over these past few months, he'd trained—harder than he ever had before—and he smiled while doing it. Kraekon pushed himself as hard as he could, resting only when necessary, so that when the pride of the Luminous Workshop came knocking, they'd find the head of Duskwatch to be their oldest friend, ready to do whatever was necessary to make a brighter future for Last Light.